the village of Chak Kawsa, short of Narabal, a grenade came sailing over from the right, bounced on the bonnet of my Gypsy before going into the bushes to the left of the road where it exploded harmlessly. The QRT swung into action, cordoning off the area and rushing into the lanes and by-lanes of the village, but the perpetrator had disappeared. The blast had been heard far and wide, and there were immediate inquiries about the cause. Since no harm had been done, we decided to pass it off as a tyre burst—not wanting to give unnecessary credit to the terrorists. 16 September is my father's birthday; maybe his Patronus was guarding me.

The months just went past in a blur. One operation after the other. Some hits and a few misses too, from which we learnt our lessons and improved our battle drills even more. In the January 2003 'Honours and Awards' list, I was awarded the Sena Medal (Distinguished). In February, I was nominated for the Higher Command course commencing in July, so that meant my tenure as a CO would come to an end. I enjoyed every moment and hour of my tenure. I am often asked which was my best tenure or which was the high point of my career. My answer, unhesitatingly, is the tenure when I had the honour and privilege of commanding 2 RR (SIKH LI).

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